



High-end Smartphones

Quite on the expected lines, smartphones over the year 2013 became more and more powerful. But, the sheer spike was unexpected for some, because it would just take a couple of months at the max to have a new flagship come along and snatch the mantle of best performer. The Samsung Galaxy S4, the HTC One, the Sony Xperia Z1 - all led the performance charts at one point of time or the other.

However, it wasn't as simple as saying that a new phone came along every once in a while. Hardware, across the board, received major upgrades. While Samsung bumped up the clock speed and the number of cores in its Exynos processor range for the flagships, the likes of HTC One relied on the Qualcomm Snapdragon 600 at the same time. The likes of the Sony Xperia Z1 and the LG G2 benefited by the launch of the Qualcomm Snapdragon 800 and to their credit, took full advantage of that. But, the most heart warming development was the arrival of two brands, who we hope succeed in the smartphone space - Intel and Lenovo. The Lenovo K900, powered by the Intel Atom Z2580 processor, did extremely well, at a rather affordable price tag.

The year really wouldn't be complete without the iPhone refresh. The "cheap" iPhone 5c has exactly the same specifications as the iPhone 5, but with a plastic shell in various colours. The major upgrade though, is the iPhone 5s. And it's no surprise that it is one of our top smartphones of the year.

Zero1 Winner

Sony Xperia Z1

Powered by the Qualcomm Snapdragon 800 processor, the Xperia Z1 is by far the most powerful Android smartphone you can buy in India, today. Maybe, by the time you read this, the Nexus 5 will come around and change the equation. But, we are not getting bogged down by that fact right now. Sony seems to be intent on building a design identity, much like Samsung has done. Which is why, the Xperia Z1 follows pretty much the same design theme and materials seen in the Xperia Z and the Xperia Z Ultra. That's a good thing, except that the glass on the back needs to be handled with care, because it gets scratched easily. The Xperia Z1 was shadowed closely by the LG G2, which also has the same pro-



◀ HIGH-END:
SONY XPERIA Z1
Price: ₹38,999

cessor and a much better IPS display. But the Z1 is the undisputed leader in our benchmark tests. If the Sony Xperia Z1 falls in your budget, buy it without any hesitation. The phone is more than capable of handling load and if Sony does push the latest Android updates to it, you shouldn't see a stutter.

Notable Mentions

Apple iPhone 5s

The iPhone 5s is a completely different beast from any iPhone before it, both in terms of hardware and software. The A7 processor is logically a major upgrade over the predecessor, but the bigger change is the M7 co-processor, which picks up data from various sensors even while the phone is asleep. This provides a major boost to some apps, including fitness and navigation apps. Apple also introduced 64-bit architecture with the new processor, and to kick it off, ported all of Apple's own apps to it. Along the way, existing apps will get updated to the 64-bit architecture and of course, the enhanced biometrics are not bad either.



Apple iPhone 5s

Price: ₹71,500



LG Nexus 5 (by Google)

Price: ₹32,999

LG Nexus 5 (by Google)

The Nexus 4, through this year, has fallen behind the newer Android flagships. The Nexus 5, expected to be in India soon (at the time of writing), will bring the Nexus smartphones back on the level. It packs in a bigger screen this time around - a 5-inch Full HD IPS+, with Gorilla Glass 3. Those who cannot suffer other Android phones because of the customizations and skins, will be delighted.